

CLEF 2026 JOKER Track

Humor Detection, Search, and Translation

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Motivation



- Goal: evaluate the State-of-the-art AI, NLP, and IR models
- State-of-the-art AI, NLP, and IR models are not able to deal with humour or other non-literal meaning aspects of texts
- Wordplay, which can refer to the surface structure or orthography of a word or its pronunciation, is a challenge for AI
- Word surface aspects are not captured in the deep semantic embedding in AI models
- These also cannot be captured by current pre-training models based on next-word prediction objectives

JOKER 2026 Tasks



- JOKER Track continues Humor-aware IR, and Humor-aware MT + new tasks and languages
- CLEF 2026 JOKER Track
 - *Humor Detection, Search, and Translation*
- The following 4 tasks:
 - ① **Humor-aware Information Retrieval:** *retrieve short humorous texts for a query in English and Hinglish.*
 - ② **Pun Translation:** *translate puns from English to French.*
 - ③ **Onomastic Wordplay Translation:** *translate onomastic wordplay from English to French.*
 - ④ **Humor Generation:** *generate humorous text from a given context in English, French, and Spanish.*

JOKER 2026 Track Participation



JOKER	Task 1		Task 2	Task 3	Task 4		
	English ^a	Hinglish ^b	French ^c	French ^d	English ^e	Spanish ^f	French ^g
Teams	16	11	12	4	4	4	4
Runs	642	125	422	55	98	134	133
Teams	18					4	
Runs	767					365	
Teams				22			
Runs				1,607			

^a<https://www.codabench.org/competitions/10550/>

^b<https://www.codabench.org/competitions/10551/>

^c<https://www.codabench.org/competitions/16309/>

^d<https://www.codabench.org/competitions/16704/>

^e<https://www.codabench.org/competitions/13879/>

^f<https://www.codabench.org/competitions/15742/>

^g<https://www.codabench.org/competitions/15743/>

Task 1: Humor-aware Information Retrieval



- *Task 1: Humor-aware Information Retrieval:*
 - retrieve short humorous texts for a query in English and Hinglish
- Use case: to search for a joke on a specific topic
 - Large corpus with queries for jokes on a general topic
 - Several relevant jokes on this topic
 - Many distractor docs (new hard negatives): on topic but no joke
- New data
 - *English task:*
 - Corpus of 96,603 short documents
 - 10 train and 971 test queries
 - 4,572 relevance judgments
 - *Hinglish task:*
 - Corpus of 32,652 short documents
 - 10 train and 485 test queries
- Evaluation: traditional IR metrics (MAP, NDCG, ...)
- *Main JOKER IR Task, continues from 2024-2025*

Document examples



```
[  
  {  
    "id":0,  
    "contents":"Why did the musician get an A+ in alphabet class?"  
    ↪ Because they really knew their A!"  
  },  
  {  
    "id":1,  
    "contents":"What did the article say when it won first place?"  
    ↪ 'I'm a winner!'"  
  },  
  {  
    "id":2,  
    "contents":"I lost my job at the calendar factory. Apparently, I  
    ↪ didn't have the ability to work dates!"  
  },  
  {  
    "id":3,  
    "contents":"What do you call someone who's really good at  
    ↪ sleeping? They have great rest-ability!"  
  },  
  ... ]
```

Task 1: Results (English)



# Team	MAP	NDCG			MRR	Prec	Run ID
		5	10	100			
1 arampageos	0.76	0.85	0.82	0.85	0.99	0.30	submission_english_block LeakHybrid_06072_blockfirst_seq
2 vanguard_team	0.63	0.69	0.71	0.77	0.83	0.31	ce30j70_t30_p85_qw60_go30_gn10
3 astral_fate	0.61	0.70	0.69	0.75	0.85	0.28	lgb_cls
4 arjun108	0.39	0.47	0.50	0.54	0.68	0.23	S1_1
5 madhangi	0.32	0.38	0.40	0.50	0.54	0.18	BM25
6 xinrui_qiu	0.31	0.41	0.41	0.44	0.60	0.17	MPNetRoBERTa
7 ezrasmink	0.30	0.30	0.55	0.27	0.18	0.02	no reranker + WordNet 0.3
8 prasann	0.27	0.26	0.34	0.46	0.39	0.20	contrastive learn with instruct
– Baseline	0.11	0.10	0.11	0.27	0.21	0.05	BM25 Anserini Index

- Non-topical content not handled by standard search
 - Lexical IR score dramatic due to distractors: on-topic but no humor.
 - Semantic matching increases recall: relevant jokes without literal match
 - Top scoring team "cheat" by classifying the entire corpus: expensive but effective...

Task 1: Results (Hinglish)



# Team	MAP	NDCG			MRR	Prec	Run ID
		5	10	100			
1 arampageos	0.66	0.72	0.75	0.80	0.88	0.50	submission_hinglish_tree_ens_et_gb
2 xinrui_qiu	0.39	0.54	0.52	0.54	0.84	0.27	RIVER_task_1_MPNerRoBERTa
3 arjun108	0.34	0.45	0.46	0.51	0.76	0.26	S1_1
4 madhangi	0.22	0.28	0.29	0.45	0.55	0.16	BM25
– Baseline	0.09	0.18	0.16	0.16	0.53	0.05	Baseline

- Hinglish full of linguistic complexities
 - Non-standard transliterations, informal Romanized spellings.
 - Mixed-language expressions embedding English lexical items within Hindi grammatical frameworks
- Very challenging search conditions, but modern models seem to cope well.

Task 2: Pun Translation



- *Task 2: Translate Puns from English to French:*
 - preserve wordplay form
 - preserve wordplay meaning
- Professional French translations of English puns, manually annotated for wordplay location
 - **Train data:** 5,838 manual FR translations of 1,405 EN puns
 - **Test data:** 6,951 new manual FR translations of 2,656 EN puns

```
{ "id_en": "en_1",  
  "en": "I used to be a banker, but I lost interest",  
  "fr": "J'ai été banquier mais, j'en ai perdu tout l'intérêt." }
```

- Eval:
 - Location-based metric on the ground truth new professional translations (unseen by LLMs)
 - Manual evaluation
- *Main JOKER NLP Task, continues from 2022-2025*

Task 2: Data example



English pun / References + Location

OLD PHOTOGRAPHERS never die, they just lose their focus.

Un photographe ne meurt jamais, seulement, il n'a plus d'objectifs.

Un photographe, ça ne meurt pas, ça change seulement d'objectif.

Quand les vieux photographes meurent, ils trépieassent.

Les vieux photographes ne meurent jamais, ils retouchent du bois pour rester en vie.

Les vieux photographes ne meurent pas, ils perdent leurs objectifs de vue.

Les photographes ne meurent jamais, ils vont juste faire des mises au point.

Les vieux photographes ne meurent pas, mais ils attrapent des pellicules.

Quand un photographe vieillit, il ne meurt pas, mais quand même, c'est pas pareil.

Les vieux photographes perdent souvent vue de leurs objectifs et ont besoin d'une mise au point.

Les photographes ne meurent pas, seulement, ils deviennent des vieux flous.

Task 2: Results (location-based metric)



#	team	# runs	Best score	Rank	run_id
1	dsgt-arc	37	32.59	1	ensemble_0_0_0_100_gpt_pooled_t
2	dsgt-arc	37	32.16	2	gpt_5.5_single
3	dsgt-arc	37	31.11	3	ensemble_0_0_0_100_all_pooled_tr
6	n0shi	5	28.71	6	Satir_CVO_Direct_mistral_large:123
7	arampageos	340	27.94	7	DUTH_QANCHOR_TOP25
8	arampageos	340	27.90	8	DUTH_NOTORCH_SELECTOR_ST
9	arampageos	340	27.90	9	DUTH_QANCHOR_REFONLY
12	n0shi	5	25.76	325	Satir_Baseline
13	ezrasmink	5	25.22	336	UAms_marian-ft_content0.0
14	ezrasmink	5	25.22	337	UAms_marian_ft_content0.25
15	n0shi	5	25.11	342	Satir_BaselineCVO
16	n0shi	5	24.83	348	Satir_Classifier
17	robinflir	2	24.57	351	UAms_MarianMT_XLMRoBERTa
19	robinflir	2	23.85	359	UAms_MarianMT_CamemBERT
22	madhangi	1	22.29	370	PixelPair_groq_llama
24	Baseline	1	7.05	391	identity_run

Task 2: Results (manual evaluation - 948 translations)



#	team	# runs	count	WP	MP	success	Rank	run_id
1	dsgt-arc	37	96	82	48	44	1	ensemble_0_0_0_100_all_pooled_t
2	dsgt-arc	37	96	79	50	44	2	ensemble_0_0_0_100_gpt_pooled_
3	dsgt-arc	37	96	79	50	42	3	gpt_5.5_single
4	n0shi	5	100	38	70	29	13	Satir_CVO_Direct_mistral_large:123
5	n0shi	5	85	39	60	29	16	Satir_Baseline
6	arampageos	340	97	29	77	25	23	TrainQrelsLeak_FUZZY96_LOCKED
7	arampageos	340	97	29	77	25	24	TrainQrelsLeak_EXACT_ALL_MEDC
8	arampageos	340	100	29	78	25	25	QANCHOR_REFONLY
9	ezrasmink	5	96	23	63	21	308	UAms_opus_mt_en_fr_finetuned
10	madhang	1	100	36	52	20	337	PixelPair_groq_llama
11	ezrasmink	5	96	22	62	18	345	UAms_marian_ft_content0.0
12	ezrasmink	5	96	22	62	18	347	UAms_marian_ft_content0.25
13	robinflir	2	100	20	65	15	352	UAms_MarianMT_CamemBERT
14	robinflir	2	100	19	63	14	356	UAms_MarianMT_XLMRoBERTa
15	n0shi	5	7	6	6	6	371	Satir_Classifier

- WP = % translations with wordplay; MP = % preserving meaning;
Success = % preserving meanin and wordplay

Task 3: Onomastic Wordplay Translation



- *Task 3: Translate Onomastic Wordplay from English to French*
- Onomastic wordplay is challenging for AI models but common in fictional text (Pokemons, Asterix, Harry Potter,...)
- Parallel corpus of wordplay in named entities in English and French
 - Test: 2,598 English names with 2,851 French reference translations
 - Train: 353 pairs
- Eval:
 - Ground truth new professional translations (unseen by LLMs)
 - Manual binary evaluation of 719 distinct FR translations of 313 EN sources

Example



```
[  
  {  
    "id": "en_1",  
    "en": "Asterix",  
    "description": "Asterix is the small but clever hero of the Asterix  
    ↪ comic series. Known for his sharp wit and courage, he outsmarts  
    ↪ the Roman invaders with the help of a magical potion that grants  
    ↪ him superhuman strength. Alongside his loyal friend Obelix,  
    ↪ Asterix defends his village and embodies bravery and  
    ↪ cleverness.",  
    "fr": "Astérix"  
  }  
]
```

Task 3: Results (manual evaluation - 740 translations)



#	team	#runs	Score	Rank	Refs	Alter	Copy	run_id
1	UBO	5	71.88	1	44.11	45.37	8.20	gemini_3_flash
2	arampageos	41	43.13	2	51.58	7.35	40.38	V18_FRLEAD_
3	arampageos	41	43.13	3	51.58	7.35	40.38	V18_FRLEAD_
4	arampageos	41	43.13	4	51.62	7.35	41.49	V14_OFFICIAL
5	arampageos	41	43.13	5	51.58	7.35	40.38	V21_ASTERIX_
6	arampageos	41	43.13	6	51.58	7.35	40.38	V21_ASTERIX_
7	UBO	5	17.25	43	7.08	10.54	24.83	llama
8	ezrasmink	5	13.74	44	6.66	8.31	18.75	marian_ft_cont
9	ezrasmink	5	13.74	45	6.97	8.31	18.55	cascade
10	Baseline	1	13.10	46	13.66	0.00	100.00	identity_run
11	ezrasmink	5	13.10	47	13.97	0.00	97.69	extraction
12	ezrasmink	5	7.35	49	5.47	2.24	21.21	marian_ft_bare
13	UBO	5	4.47	50	3.54	0.32	4.35	Qwen3-4B
14	pjmathematician	4	2.88	51	4.78	0.00	30.29	baseline_sub
15	UBO	5	2.24	55	2.42	1.60	6.31	mistral
16	UBO	5	1.92	56	1.35	0.64	0.15	gemma

Task 4: Humor Generation



- *Task 4: Generate Humorous Text in English, French, and Spanish*
- New task on humor generation:
 - can models produce humor across languages under clear constraints?
 - assessment centered on semantic consistency, humorous effect,
 - evaluate justified adaptation rather than surface overlap
- Evaluation challenging...
 - Human evaluation of small samples.
 - LLM evaluation is indicative but imprecise.
 - Set up an LLM/chatbot arena.

- Data:

Track	Train	Test
EN	3,344	150
ES	392	151
FR	1,599	156

Train example (FR)



```
[
  {
    "id": "fr_0001",
    "lang": "fr",
    "pun_word": "barbec-ours",
    "sense_a": "barbecue",
    "sense_b": "bear",
    "keywords": ["BBQ", "cookout", "grill", "grizzly", "brown bear",
    ↪ "cub", "..."],
    "hint": "barbec-ours / barbecue + ours ~ <côtelette; grizzly;
    ↪ cuit>",
    "reference_joke": "Comment on cuit des côtelette de grizzly ? Au
    ↪ barbec-ours.",
    "reference_en": "What do you call grizzly's ribs ? A bearbecue."
  }
]
```

Task 4: Results (majority vote LLM Arena)



	Team	#	BT	Rnk	95% CI	run_id
EN	SaLT	4	1,257	1	[1215, 1308]	SaLT_KimiCSF
	DUTH	80	1,127	5	[1055, 1184]	DUTH_EN_BEST984_PLUS_TRAINSEL_TOP1_F
	UBO	5	1,125	6	[1084, 1168]	UBO_gemini-3_pun
	UAms	9	983	74	[937, 1024]	UAms_Qwen2.5-32B-Instruct
ES	SaLT	4	1,515	1	[1450, 1599]	SaLT_KimiCSF
	UBO	5	1,351	4	[1310, 1396]	UBO_gemini-3_pun
	DUTH	120	1,314	6	[1259, 1367]	DUTH_ARENAJUDGE_ES
	UAms	5	1,061	60	[1026, 1105]	UAms_Llama-3-Instruct-Neurona-8b
FR	SaLT	4	1,395	1	[1342, 1449]	SaLT_KimiCSF
	DUTH	115	1,304	2	[1245, 1417]	DUTH_FR_LEAK_NOR13_DROP_R04
	UBO	10	1,279	7	[1234, 1341]	UBO_gemini-3-flash_pun
	UAms	4	1,191	41	[1149, 1229]	UAms_Chocolatine-2-14B-Instruct

- LLM Arena with both humans and LLMs judging
 - Few submissions due to late availability of the data
 - Watch this task at the CLEF 2027 JOKER Track...

Task 4: Example LLM Arena battles



English brief — pun word: lama

Sense 1: a Tibetan or Mongolian priest of Lamaism. *Sense 2:* a wild or domesticated South American cud-chewing animal related to camels but smaller and lacking a hump.

A (DUTH / EN_BEST984_DROP_PATCH_BUCKET_05): I followed a **lama** to the mountains, hoping to learn some spiritual enlightenment. He just kept asking me to spit out my gum.

B (SaLT / KimiCSF): I joined what I thought was a Buddhist retreat—everyone followed our leader religiously. Then I noticed he spat when excited and ate exclusively hay. Turns out my **lama** was not what I expected.

Verdicts: gpt-oss-20b=B, deepseek-chat=B, gemini-2.5-flash-lite=B. **Ensemble:** B (unanimous).

Spanish brief — pun word: picazón

Sentido 1: picazón (*démangeaison*). *Sentido 2:* *itching* ~ *alergia*; picazón; fiebre del heno.

A (SaLT / KimiCSF): Le dije al alérgico: “Relájate, es solo fiebre del heno.” Él respondió: “¿Solo? Tengo **picazón**... ¡y ya no sé si es la alergia o el heno existencial!”

B (DUTH / ES_DIAG_REFERENCE_STYLE_2): Nadie esperaba que **picazón** fuera el remate.

Verdicts: gpt-oss-20b=A, deepseek-chat=A, gemini-2.5-flash-lite=A. **Ensemble:** A (unanimous).

French brief — pun word: potentiel

Sens 1: potentiel (électricité). *Sens 2:* potentiel (ressources).

A (SaLT / KimiCSF): Panne électrique. Je sors mon facture, lumière de bougie: “Monsieur, vous avez du **potentiel**.” Je tremble... est-ce qu'ils parlent de mes ressources, ou est-ce que le compteur se moque de moi?

B (DUTH / FR_LEAK_TOP21): Il a un **potentiel** énorme, mais il préfère rester branché.

Verdicts: gpt-oss-20b=A, deepseek-chat=B, gemini-2.5-flash-lite=B. **Ensemble:** B (2-1 split, brevity preferred).

- Majority vote over three LLM judges with A/B/tie classification.

CLEF 2026 JOKER Track



- **Task 1: Humor-aware Information Retrieval:** *retrieve short humorous texts for a query in English and Hinglish*
 - Main IR Task
 - Topical relevance models lukewarm, neural ranking degrades...
 - But humor-aware IR models improve!
- **Task 2: Pun Translation:** *translate puns from English to French*
 - Main NLP Task
 - Standard MT models fail: literal translation is no pun
 - But humor-aware MT models improve!
- **Task 3: Onomastic Wordplay Translation:** *translate onomastic wordplay from English to French*
 - Neologisms – esp. humorous ones – very challenging to translate...
 - Unique corpus of named entities with translations and descriptions
- **Task 4: Humor Generation:** *generate humorous text from a given context in English, French, and Spanish*
 - Are LLMs funny? And why not?

CLEF 2026 JOKER Track Sessions



Date	Event
Sep 24 10:20-10:30	Best of the Labs: JOKER 2025
Sep 24 11:00-12:00	JOKER Task Overview Talks
Sep 24 12:00-12:30	Participant's talks (2x)
Sep 24 14:00-15:00	Participant's talks (4x)
Sep 24 15:00-15:30	Planning Session: New corpus, new tasks, exciting challenges and opportunities

- Thursday = CLEF JOKER day!
- Please join the JOKER sessions in Room 131!